

IDENTIFYING PROVEN PROBLEM-SOLVING SKILLS

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Understand the relationship between addiction and partner relational conflicts.
2. Develop the skills necessary to maintain open and effective communication, sexual intimacy, and enjoyable time with a partner.
3. Clarify and more effectively use innate strengths and resources in the community and environment to achieve and maintain recovery from addiction.
4. Reframe both addiction and conflict as problems to be solved, having much in common with other problems already solved in the past.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE PARTNER RELATIONSHIP CONFLICT

- Balancing Recovery, Family, and Work
- Communication Skills
- Creating a Family Ritual
- Forming Stable Relationships
- Identifying Conflict Themes
- Is It Romance or Is It Fear?
- Is My Anger Due to Unmet Expectations?
- Learning to Ask Instead of Demand
- Negotiating Skills for Success
- Respect or Fear?
- Setting and Maintaining Boundaries

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE USEFUL

- Family Conflicts
- Parent-Child Relational Problem
- Suicidal Ideation

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The “Identifying Proven Problem-Solving Skills” activity is intended for clients who are suffering from learned helplessness or low self-esteem and as a result are failing to use resources and abilities they have available to them to achieve and maintain recovery and productive interpersonal relationships. It guides the client in a systematic self-assessment to identify general problem-solving skills he or she has successfully used in other situations, then to plan strategies for using these skills to address these issues. Follow-up could include assignments to keep a journal on the outcomes of the strategies identified through this exercise and report back to the therapist or group on successes and lessons learned.

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This assignment will strengthen your recovery program quickly and help you with other issues, especially those that put you at risk for relapse (e.g., relationship conflicts, parenting, managing money). Everyone has problem-solving methods they have used in past situations, and we each have a unique combination of talents. In this exercise you will look at your past successes in all areas of life to find the recovery tools and life skills you already have and know how to use.

1. Often when we enter addiction treatment, we hear a lot of unfamiliar terms. Staff and more experienced clients use words like sharing, dependence, abstinence, surrender, denial, recovery, Higher Power, and others in ways we may not have heard before. It can seem like having to learn a new language. In this space, please list words you've heard in treatment or therapy that are new to you or are being used in new ways you're not used to hearing.

2. We may also get the impression that we will have to learn a whole new set of skills to solve the problems that brought us into treatment. When staff and fellow clients talk about what has to be done to stay clean and sober, these terms are often equally unfamiliar. Please list any tasks or actions you've heard people talking about that seem foreign and unfamiliar.

3. However, this impression is misleading. None of us grow up without learning some ways to solve problems in our lives, and many of those methods will work on any kind of problem, including addiction and substance abuse. Of course, using addictive behaviors was one of our problem-solving tools, and that one is obviously not going to work here. But you have used other methods to solve problems in your life. Please list five situations in which you have solved problems or accomplished goals.

4. Now please examine the list of problem-solving/goal-accomplishing skills, traits, and methods listed below, and check off the ones you used in the five situations you just listed.

- ☐ Asking others for help
- ☐ Attention to details
- ☐ Being alert
- ☐ Being decisive
- ☐ Being persistent
- ☐ Brainstorming—generating lots of ideas then picking out the best ones
- ☐ Breaking a big problem down into small steps
- ☐ Courtesy
- ☐ Defining a goal and steps to reach it
- ☐ Explaining and teaching things to others
- ☐ Finding alternative ways to do things
- ☐ Flexibility
- ☐ Following instructions
- ☐ Helping others
- ☐ Humor
- ☐ Listening carefully
- ☐ Negotiating
- ☐ Open-mindedness
- ☐ Organizing other people
- ☐ Patience
- ☐ Persuasion
- ☐ Planning use of time
- ☐ Practicing a difficult task until it got easy
- ☐ Practicing an easy task, then working up to harder ones
- ☐ Praying
- ☐ Recognizing patterns
- ☐ Researching needed information (asking people, using books, the Internet, etc.)
- ☐ Sharing
- ☐ Studying
- ☐ Taking notes

- _____ Tools suited for a job
- _____ Trial and error (just trying different things until something works)
- _____ Using a method that worked in a similar situation
- _____ Watching others, then using the same methods that work for them
- _____ Working alone
- _____ Working in a team

5. As you can see, the process of solving problems breaks down into skills that can be used in many different situations. Even if you haven't faced this problem before, you already have many skills that will help you succeed. Now go back and circle the skills or strengths you think will help you to gain and maintain recovery from addiction and solve your other problems so that your stress level is as low as you can get it.
6. The items from this list that most people find most useful are: all of the above! However, each individual uses them differently. Please go over the list in question 4 carefully, and pick the five items that are most important in your problem-solving approach. In other words, which five do you use the most? After you pick your top five, write an example of how you can use each to work on your recovery. For example, if you picked "researching information," some ways you could use it might be to read books on several different approaches to recovery, talking to people who are succeeding at the same task, finding Web sites on the Internet with information about recovery from addiction, and so on.

Problem-Solving Skill or Trait

How I Can Use It in Recovery

_____	_____
_____	_____
_____	_____
_____	_____
_____	_____

7. Many alcoholics and addicts, once they get the chemicals out of their systems and are no longer impaired, find that they are smart, creative, funny, hard-working, loyal, and generous people. How many of those words fit you? What qualities do other people value in you? For this question, your assignment is to talk to three people who know you well. Ask them what qualities and abilities of yours they think will be most helpful to you in staying clean and sober. Write their answers here.

How can you apply those same qualities and abilities to other problems?

8. Finally, here are ways in which some particular skills and strengths can help people in recovery. If you have these skills or strengths, here are ways you can use them:
- a. *Good communication skills.* Working with others—clinical staff, recovery program members, sponsors, clergy, friends, family—and improving relationships.
 - b. *High energy and determination.* Continuing to work your program even when you're temporarily discouraged; helping others.
 - c. *Sense of humor.* Coping with difficult or painful moments; avoiding self-pity or false pride; enjoying fellowship with other recovering people.
 - d. *Spirituality.* Improving a relationship with a Higher Power; staying clear on what your values are; having faith to carry you through hard times.
 - e. *Creativity.* Finding new ways to help oneself and others; putting old tools to new uses.
9. Think about the parts of getting and staying clean and sober, and of tackling other important problems, that are the hardest or most nerve-wracking for you. Pick three specific problems or situations that have you worried. List them here, then write a few sentences for each describing how you can use the methods and qualities we've been talking about to tackle each of those three issues. After you've finished this handout, talk about it with your therapist or group the next time you meet.

Problem 1: _____

How I can tackle it: _____

Problem 2: _____

How I can tackle it: _____

Problem 3: _____

How I can tackle it: _____

Above all, remember that whatever questions or problems you face in recovery, someone else has faced them before you. If they succeeded, so can you—just pick out some people who are a lot like you and overcame similar problems, find out what they did, and try doing the same things.

Be sure to bring this handout to your next therapy session, and be prepared to talk about your

thoughts and feelings about the exercise.